

The year 2003. The world woke up with a new perspective on history, a revelation that would shock many and create avid interest in the art of secret communication. Dan Brown's *Da Vinci Code* created a furore among critics and readers alike. While the former chose to point out the literary inconsistencies, the latter rushed to read up more on the hidden layers of Da Vinci's art – in other words, their first ever tryst with cryptography. However, this science of secret communication has been as old as mankind itself. Well, almost.

Starting simple

Early evidence of cryptography indicates that it has been around since Biblical times. The Bible Code, also known as the Torah Code, is supposedly a series of secret messages embedded in the text of the Torah. This has been decoded using ELS (Equidistance Letter Sequence) and is a highly debatable topic.

It is believed that cryptography began approximately around 2000 B.C. in Egypt. The famous hieroglyphics adorning the tombs of rulers depicted the lives of the kings and the great acts done by them. Intentionally kept in a cryptic mode, these hieroglyphics were only used for an ornamental purpose rather than for secrecy. Soon, this system became obsolete.

Storing Intelligence

Since cryptography is mysterious in its approach, this science began to be associated with the dark arts. And since most early cryptographers were usually the intelligentsia or the scientists, commoners considered them to



Some say secret codes and symbolism exist in Da Vinci's paintings